

The Archivist's Lantern

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Wing That Remembers Names

The sealed wing had been sealed for as long as any of them could remember, which in the Labyrinth Library meant longer than ordinary time accounted for.

It stood at the far end of the eastern corridor, past the shelf of tide atlases and the display case of miniature globes, behind a door of pale gray stone. The door had no handle. Where a handle should have been, someone had mortared the gap smooth, as if the intention had always been for entering to be earned rather than assumed.

Natalia had walked past it every Thursday for months without stopping. Today, she stopped.

"That door is breathing," she said.

Maya came to stand beside her. Alana followed without being called, tablet already open, recording dimensions by instinct. SPARK hovered at shoulder height, his chest panel cycling through soft amber.

The door was not, technically, breathing. But the stone along its frame was warm in a way stone had no ordinary reason to be, and at its base, a thin line of amber light leaked from beneath — steady as a held breath, slow as something patient.

"The heat signature is inconsistent with ambient temperature," Alana said. "Whatever is inside has been generating warmth for a long time."

"It smells like brass," Natalia said. "And old ink."

Maya pressed one palm flat against the center of the stone. The warmth was real. "Why would anyone seal a warm room?"

SPARK adjusted his optic. "Records indicate this wing was closed by the archivist on record twelve years ago. No stated reason. The catalogue entry simply reads: not yet."

Natalia read those two words twice. Not yet. They did not say never. They said wait.

She crouched at the base of the door and looked more carefully at the amber line. It was not light from a lamp. It had texture — a flicker at irregular intervals, a softening and a brightening, as if it were responding to something the room alone could feel.

"It is a lantern," SPARK said, his voice quieter than usual. "There is an active flame source inside. It has been burning for twelve years."

Alana looked up sharply. "A flame burning unsupervised for twelve years is a significant anomaly."

"Unless it was left on purpose," Natalia said.

No one answered immediately, because they all understood the difference between a thing forgotten and a thing

left behind to wait. One was a mistake. The other was a form of trust directed at someone not yet arrived.

From behind the door came a sound — not loud, not urgent. It was the soft creak of a name settling into paper, the way a ship settles against a dock at the end of a long voyage.

Maya stepped back and studied the sealed gap where the handle had been removed. Then she looked at the floor. Pressed into the stone at the threshold was a single word, worn nearly smooth by years of no one standing on it:

REMEMBER.

"We need to get in," Natalia said.

"Yes," Maya agreed. "We do."

SPARK's amber light steadied to gold.

"Beginning analysis," he said. "Beginning now."

Chapter 2 — Brass and Borrowed Light

The door opened not to a key but to a question.

SPARK found the mechanism after forty minutes of careful scanning: a thin channel carved into the stone beside the sealed handle gap, too narrow to be decorative, too regular to be erosion. It ran from floor to ceiling in an almost imperceptible groove, and at eye level it widened into a small recess the shape of a cupped hand.

"It is waiting for something to be placed here," SPARK said.

Alana tried a lens from her toolkit. Maya tried the spine of a field notebook. Natalia stood still and thought about what the word remember meant to a room that had been sealed for twelve years.

She reached into her bag and took out the small brass compass that had been a gift from her grandmother — the one she carried not for navigation but for comfort, because it always pointed somewhere with calm certainty regardless of how lost she felt. She placed it in the recess.

The mechanism accepted it. Not permanently. The compass would be returned when they left. But for now, the stone recognized the offering: something carried close, something trusted.

The door slid inward without sound.

The room on the other side was not large. It was a single archive chamber, no bigger than a generous sitting room, lined on three walls with wooden shelving that rose to the ceiling. The shelves held books, ledgers, and thin card-folders, all organized with the precision of someone who had loved this work. A reading desk occupied the center with a lamp-stand beside it, and on the lamp-stand stood the lantern.

It was brass. It was old. Its glass panels were clouded with age and the gentle residue of long burning, and its flame — small, amber, entirely steady — had clearly been burning without interruption since the day the door was sealed.

The light it cast was not ordinary.

When it fell on the spines of the books along the shelves, names appeared in the wood between the titles. Not the titles themselves. Names. Reader names, written in a script that seemed to surface from beneath the grain, like letters floating up through shallow water.

Maya stepped closer to the nearest shelf. "There's a name here. Between this one and this one. Miriam H., 1987."

Alana scanned a second shelf. "Every gap between books holds a name. Dozens. Hundreds, possibly."

Natalia stood very still at the center of the room and turned slowly, watching the light move across every surface it reached. Where the lantern's glow touched, names woke and held themselves briefly visible, then faded as the light moved on.

"This is what it does," she said. "The lantern illuminates the people who read here. Not the books. The readers."

SPARK held his sensors steady. "Each name includes a date and a book title. It is a record of who came, what they read, and when."

Maya's voice had changed from curious to careful. "And someone sealed this room with that still burning."

"Not to hide it," Natalia said. "To keep it going until someone was ready to understand what it was for."

The flame tilted toward her in the still air, as if agreeing.

Outside, the labyrinth hummed quietly, patient as it had always been.

Chapter 3 — The Ledger of Readers

On the reading desk, beneath a careful weight of polished stone, lay the ledger.

It was not the largest book in the room — several of the bound volumes on the upper shelves dwarfed it. But it held itself differently from the other books, with the particular gravity of objects that have been deliberately left rather than merely stored. Its cover was deep green cloth, worn soft at the corners. On the front, embossed in gilt letters that the years had thinned but not erased:

RECORD OF READERS BY LIGHT AND BY NAME

Natalia lifted the stone weight and set it aside. She opened the ledger to the first page.

The handwriting was uniform and clear — someone who had written in it regularly and with attention. Each entry

occupied three lines:

Name. Date. Title read. And then, below those, a fourth line in a slightly smaller script that was clearly added later, after reflection:

Why it mattered.

"There are hundreds of entries," Alana said, leaning close without touching. She had trained herself not to reach for old documents before she understood what they were.

"Thousands," SPARK corrected gently. "I estimate between two thousand and twenty-three hundred entries across the visible pages, based on line density."

Maya turned pages slowly, reading entries at random.

"Yusuf A., October 1962. Read: A Field Guide to Migratory Birds. Why it mattered: He was moving to a new country and needed to believe that traveling long distances to find where you belong was a natural act."

She turned more pages.

"Serena L., March 1979. Read: The History of Paper. Why it mattered: Her mother was ill and she wanted to understand how something fragile could last."

Natalia sat down in the reading chair. The lamp's brass caught the lantern light and doubled it softly. Outside the circle of warmth, the room was dim.

"Someone recorded not just what people read," she said. "They recorded why."

Alana sat on the edge of the desk. "That is an unusual thing to know. A reader's reason for choosing a book is usually private."

"Maybe people told the archivist," Maya said. "Or maybe the archivist was observant enough to understand without being told."

SPARK moved to the back of the ledger, where the entries became more recent. The handwriting remained the same throughout — the same hand, across decades, which was its own quiet mystery.

The last entry was dated twelve years ago. It read:

Natalia A., Alana A., Maya A., and SPARK — date unknown, coming when ready. Title: the one they need. Why it will matter: because they will remember.

All three sisters looked at the page.

The entry was about them. Written twelve years ago, before they had ever come to the labyrinth. Written in

absolute certainty by someone who had known they were coming.

"The archivist left this for us," Alana said.

It was not a question.

The lantern flame did not move. But the room felt very slightly warmer, in the way a room feels when something that has been waiting a long time finally understands that the wait is over.

Chapter 4 — Maya's Unmarked Page

They began with Maya because Maya asked first, which was how most things went.

She had found her name in the ledger and stood looking at it the way she looked at complex problems — head tilted, eyes moving across the line twice, three times, sorting what was true from what seemed true. The entry below theirs was blank. Their names, their description, the space for why it would matter — but no title in the book field. No record of what they had read.

"We're unfinished," she said.

"We're present," Natalia said. "There's a difference."

But Maya had moved to the shelves and was running one finger slowly along the spines, reading titles, letting the lantern's light play over each one. Names woke where the light touched: a reader from 1994 who had stood in the same spot, a girl in 1955 who had worn her school uniform on a Saturday to return a book she had finished at midnight.

"Do you know what I've never been able to say properly?" Maya said. She was not speaking to anyone in particular, which meant she was working something out. "That I read for proof."

Alana set down her tablet. "What kind of proof?"

"That things work out. That people get through the hard parts." Maya's finger paused on a thin spine near the middle of the second shelf. The lantern light fell on it and woke a name: Odessa P., 1971. "This person came back three times. Look — same name, three different years, same shelf."

SPARK confirmed it. "Odessa P., 1971, 1973, 1975. All three visits, same section of shelf."

"She was looking for something," Maya said. "Or coming back to something she already found."

Natalia watched her sister's face. There was something careful in it, something that usually stayed underneath Maya's speed and brightness. "What do you look for when you read?"

Maya took her time. Outside, a distant clock registered the hour, its chime reaching them muffled through stone.

"I look for the part where someone decides," she said at last. "Where the story could go either way and they choose the harder, better thing. I read those parts over and over." She pulled the thin volume from the shelf — it was a collection of letters written by people during difficult winters, to people they would not see again. "I think I need to know that deciding is possible. That you can always choose."

The lantern held its light steady on the spine in her hands.

A new name appeared in the wood beside the gap she had made: Maya A., today's date.

Not recorded by anyone. Not written by hand. The lantern had added it on its own, as if the room itself had witnessed and understood what she had just said aloud for the first time.

Maya looked at the name for a long moment. Then she sat cross-legged on the floor and opened the book of letters, because reading was the only honest response she knew to being genuinely seen.

SPARK dimmed his display to half-brightness, the way you lower your voice when something important is being read.

Chapter 5 — Alana's Missing Date

Alana spent twenty minutes establishing that the lantern burned at a constant temperature regardless of position in the room, that the names appeared in a spectral range consistent with phosphorescent biological ink rather than ordinary luminescence, and that the ledger's paper was significantly older than its most recent entries, which meant pages had been added to an original binding over decades.

Then she sat down on the floor beside Maya and was quiet for a while.

Maya did not push. Neither did Natalia. They had long understood that Alana arrived at things from a different direction than most people — through the structure first, the meaning second, with the feeling arriving last and sometimes very quietly, like a conclusion that had been sound all along and only needed the proof to finish writing itself.

"The entries with the most detail," Alana said finally, "are not the longest ones. The longest entries are often the most obvious — the ones where the reason for reading is public information. Grief. Exams. Moving house." She had been reading through the ledger with systematic thoroughness. "The shortest entries are the most specific. Three words, sometimes two. And those are the ones I keep returning to."

SPARK pulled up the ledger entries she had flagged and projected them in a list beside her. She had marked fourteen entries, none longer than a line:

To understand silence. Because I had forgotten. For the version of me that was afraid. Because names matter.

"These readers knew precisely why they came," Alana said. "They didn't arrive with a general desire for comfort or distraction. They arrived knowing the exact shape of what they needed."

"Is that rare?" Natalia asked.

"I think it requires a certain kind of self-knowledge." Alana looked at the lantern. "Which is harder than it sounds."

She stood and moved to the section of shelving SPARK had identified as containing scientific journals and natural histories. The lantern followed her movement with its warmth, waking names she read without comment. She stopped at a gap between a treatise on starlight refraction and a handbook of crystalline structures.

"There should be a book here," she said. "The pattern of names suggests it was frequently borrowed and returned, which means it may be in use elsewhere in the labyrinth."

She noted the gap coordinates in her tablet. Then she looked at the space itself — the absence of the thing that should be there.

"I have a missing date," she said, and her voice was as careful and as steady as her handwriting. "There was a day two years ago when I understood something important about the way I think, and I did not write it down anywhere. I thought precision required evidence. But the evidence was internal and I distrusted it." She paused. "I think the book that belongs in this gap is the one I needed then."

The lantern threw her shadow long across the floor.

In the ledger, SPARK quietly noted, a new line was filling itself in. Not the name. Not yet. Just the date — holding the space where the rest of the entry would eventually go, patient as all honest records are for the truth to arrive.

Chapter 6 — Natalia's Quiet Return

Natalia had been in the room the longest without saying much, which meant she had been thinking the most.

She sat in the reading chair with the ledger open across her knees and read from the beginning, not skimming, taking each entry at its own pace. SPARK had stopped monitoring her — or appeared to have stopped — and moved to examine the ceiling, where the lantern light also woke things: not names, up there, but dates. Years, layered across the plaster in a palimpsest of arrivals, each one a small confirmation that someone had stood in this room and been changed.

The earliest date visible was 1887.

"This room has been here for more than a hundred years," Natalia said, without looking up.

"Longer, perhaps," SPARK said. "I cannot see the full ceiling from this angle."

"But the entries in the ledger only go back to 1962." She turned to the first page again. "Someone started recording later. After the room already existed."

"The archivist," Alana said.

"Yes." Natalia turned the ledger over and looked at the back. Inside the rear cover, in handwriting smaller than the entries, was a note she had not seen before because she had not yet looked here:

I began this record because I realized no one was keeping one. Readers come and go and leave no trace except what the books carry in their margins. But the margins are not enough. Names matter. Reasons matter. A library that only records titles has not yet understood what it is for. — H.V.A., 1962

"H.V.A.," Maya said. "The archivist."

Natalia set her thumb against the initials. The ink was sixty years old and entirely certain of itself.

"They started this because they thought names mattered," she said. "And then they sealed the room twelve years ago and left the lantern burning." She looked up at her sisters. "Why would you seal a room and leave the light on?"

No one answered immediately.

"Because you were not finished," Alana said. "But you could not continue."

"Or because," Maya said slowly, "you needed someone else to continue it."

Natalia stood. She walked to the shelves and let the lantern light find her face, which it did without ceremony — warmly, as if it had been expecting to.

A name appeared on the shelf beside her. Her own name. Natalia A. And beside it, already written, the title: the ledger itself. The record of readers.

The why-it-mattered line was blank.

She understood, looking at it, that the entry was waiting not for her to read the ledger but for her to understand what the archivist had understood sixty years ago: that the act of remembering other people's reasons for reading was itself the most important thing anyone could do in this room.

She took out her own notebook — the small one she carried for thoughts that needed to be written before they escaped — and opened it to the next blank page.

She did not write anything yet. But the act of opening it felt like a beginning, and the lantern held its light steady on her hands as if to say: yes, exactly, that is how it starts.

Chapter 7 — When the Lantern Dims

On the second day, the lantern dimmed.

Not much. Not dangerously. But in the hour after they arrived and began their work — Natalia reading through the ledger's middle section, Alana searching the shelves for the missing volume, Maya making a running list of every reader who had come more than once — the flame dropped a quarter of its usual height and the amber light pulled back from the far corners of the room.

SPARK detected it first. "Fuel level decreasing. Estimated burn duration at current rate: forty-one hours."

Natalia looked up. "The lantern is running out?"

"It has been burning for twelve years. The fuel source appears to be a self-replenishing oil that responds to use of the room — I believe it has been sustained, partially, by the act of readers being present." SPARK paused. "Its continued burning may require something from us that we have not yet provided."

"We haven't finished the ledger," Alana said.

"We haven't written the final entry," Maya said. She was looking at the ledger's last page — their names, the blank title, the blank why-it-mattered line. "The archivist left our names as the last entry. Whatever we're supposed to do here, we haven't done it."

Natalia looked at the flame. It was still burning. But it had the quality of something waiting — of patience that had been patient long enough and was beginning, gently, to ask.

"What is the room for?" she said. It was not the first time she had asked the question, but she was asking it differently now, with the urgency that comes when you realize you have been circling the answer without landing on it.

SPARK moved to the central display position he used when he was about to say something careful. "The room records readers. The ledger records reasons. The lantern illuminates names." He paused. "But none of those functions has value unless someone looks at the result. A record no one reads is not a record. It is a list."

"The archivist was not just recording," Alana said. She had stopped her work on the shelves and was looking at the ledger with the expression she wore when a hypothesis was proving itself. "They were preserving the connection between reader and book. Making the invisible thing visible."

"Why does it need to be visible?" Maya asked.

It was Natalia who answered, quietly.

"Because if you don't know that someone else came before you and needed the same thing you need — needed proof, or comfort, or the specific word for a feeling you couldn't name — then reading can feel like something you do alone in the dark." She looked at the names flickering on the shelves. "The lantern makes you part of something."

The flame rose. Not dramatically. Just steadily, returning to its full height without fuss, as if it had been waiting for exactly that sentence and was satisfied.

"So the lantern sustains itself on understanding," SPARK said. He sounded genuinely moved, which he was.

"Yes," Natalia said.

Maya closed her list and looked at the ledger. "Then we'd better understand the rest of it."

Chapter 8 — The Archivist's Note

The note was folded inside the ledger's binding, sewn into the spine with careful thread, invisible unless you knew to look. SPARK found it while scanning the structural integrity of the binding — a small rectangle of paper tucked between the innermost pages and the leather backbone, pressed so flat by years that it had become part of the weight of the book.

Natalia removed it with the same care she would use for something living.

The handwriting was the same as the rear-cover inscription — H.V.A. — but smaller, closer together, as if the author had been writing fast or writing in a space that required economy.

She read it aloud.

If you are reading this, the lantern is still burning. I am glad.

I sealed this room because the ledger was in danger of being catalogued. There are people who look at records and see databases, not lives. I did not want these names sorted into something efficient. I wanted them to remain what they are: individual, specific, irreplaceable.

I left the lantern burning because I believe warmth is harder to neglect than cold. A dark room can be forgotten. A warm one asks to be entered.

I could not finish the work myself. The ledger requires readers who understand why names matter before they understand the room's purpose. Otherwise the final entry means nothing.

The final entry is not yours to write on behalf of yourselves.

It is yours to write on behalf of all the names before you.

Look at the readers who came here. Find what they held in common. Write the one sentence that is true for all of them. That sentence is the record the ledger has been waiting to close.

I believe in your reading.

— H. V. Atalay, Archivist, 1962–2014

Alana was the first to speak. "She died."

"Or left," Maya said. "Retired."

"The dates suggest she dedicated fifty-two years to this room," SPARK said quietly.

The four of them were still for a long moment. The lantern burned at full height. The names on the shelves were vivid in its light, dozens of them visible at once, a crowd of readers who had come and gone and left some record of themselves in this room.

Natalia folded the note carefully and placed it back against the ledger's spine.

"She trusted us with fifty-two years of other people's reasons," she said.

"She trusted the next readers," Alana said. "Whoever they would turn out to be."

"We need to read more carefully," Natalia said. "All of the entries. Not just the ones that catch us. All of them."

She opened the ledger to the first page again.

Maya sat on one side of her. Alana sat on the other.

SPARK projected a low, steady light to help them see, and they began.

Outside, the labyrinth went about its quiet business. The clocks in the main corridor ticked. Somewhere, a return cart moved along its rail. Ordinary library sounds — the kind that mean the work is continuing.

Inside the sealed room, three sisters read the names of everyone who had come before them, one by one, with the care that the archivist had hoped for.

Chapter 9 — Reading the Names Aloud

It took most of the day.

They divided the ledger into thirds. Not to be efficient but because some tasks require shared attention — need multiple pairs of eyes on the same material the way a long journey needs more than one person who knows the route. Natalia read the earliest entries. Alana read the middle decades. Maya read the final years before the sealing.

They read silently for a long time. Then, without discussion, they began reading aloud.

Not all of it. Selectively, the way you read aloud in a library — the lines that need to be heard.

Natalia: "Thomas B., November 1964. Read: An Ordinary History of an Ordinary Town. Why it mattered: he came from somewhere no one had thought worth writing about, and he needed proof that ordinary places had histories worth keeping."

A long pause. The lantern held all their names at once.

Alana: "Priya V., July 1983. Read: The Mathematics of Music. Why it mattered: she had been told she could love music or love numbers but not both, and she needed to be told that was wrong."

Maya, softer: "Daniel C., September 2001. Read: anything. He wrote just that — anything. Why it mattered: he needed words that had nothing to do with what was happening in the world that week. He needed a door into somewhere else."

They continued for hours. The lantern names rose and held and faded and rose again. Outside, the light in the corridor changed from afternoon to evening without anyone marking the transition.

What emerged, over hours of reading, was a pattern that Alana was the first to articulate.

"Every person in this ledger came for a reason that was, at its core, the same reason," she said. "Expressed differently. In different times, about different difficulties. But the same."

"What reason?" SPARK asked.

"They needed to know they were not alone in what they were experiencing." Alana's voice was careful and exact. "Every entry. The person who needed proof that ordinary places mattered. The person who needed to know loving two things was permitted. The person who needed somewhere else to be for a while. They all came here because they needed the company of a story."

Maya nodded. "And the lantern kept their names so the next person who came would have company too. Even from strangers."

Natalia had been sitting still. She looked at the final blank entry — their names, their waiting space — and felt the sentence arrive. Not invented. Found. The way you find a sentence that was already true and needed only to be stated.

"That's it," she said.

She picked up the pen the archivist had left in the ledger's inner margin — twelve years old, still inked, waiting — and turned to the final page.

The lantern woke every name in the room at once.

The shelves blazed with them, briefly, beautifully.

Natalia wrote.

Chapter 10 — The Return Shelf

The sentence she wrote was not long.

No reader who came to this room came alone: every name in this ledger is the company of everyone who came before.

Below it, in the space for title, she wrote: the ledger itself. The record of all of them.

Below that, in the space for why it mattered, she wrote: because the archivist understood that remembering is an act of care.

The pen ran dry on the period at the end of the last sentence, which felt right — as if the ink had known exactly how much it needed to give.

The lantern burned steady and clear.

Nothing dramatic happened. There was no sound of locks or seals or architectural resolution. The room simply settled, the way a room settles at the end of a long day when everything has been attended to and put in its right place. The warmth of the flame evened out from amber to something closer to gold. The names on the shelves stayed lit rather than flickering — held constant, visible all at once for the first time.

"It's not dimming anymore," SPARK said.

Alana scanned. "Fuel level stable. The self-replenishment mechanism appears to have fully engaged."

Maya walked the perimeter of the shelves slowly, reading names. She knew a few of them by now — Thomas, Priya, Daniel and the others they had read aloud. They felt familiar now, the way people feel familiar after you have spent time with their written words.

"What happens to the room?" she asked. "Now that the ledger's complete?"

"It was never meant to stay sealed," Natalia said. "The archivist sealed it to protect it until the right moment. The right moment is now." She looked at the door, which stood open the way they had left it. "I think it should open to the labyrinth properly. Not just for us."

Alana had been examining the shelf that held the return records — the section near the door where books brought back to this specific wing were logged. She called Natalia over.

The shelf had a small brass plate screwed into its edge. It read:

FOR BOOKS THAT KNOW THEIR READER AND READERS WHO KNOW THEIR BOOK. RETURN
HERE.

Below the plate was an empty space. Waiting.

"There are no returns logged," Alana said. "Nothing has been brought back to this wing in twelve years."

"Because the door was sealed," Maya said.

"Yes."

Natalia looked at the empty return shelf. Then she looked at the ledger — their completed ledger, with its final entry now written — and made a decision.

She placed the ledger on the return shelf.

Not to be rid of it. Not to stop using it. To return it to its purpose: to be available, on a shelf that had been waiting for exactly this, to the next person who needed to know they had not come to this room alone.

SPARK recorded the action and the timestamp.

The brass plate glowed, briefly, in the lantern light.

Chapter 11 — Keeper of Small Remembrances

The first person to find the room after the door stood open was not who they expected.

She was perhaps eleven, wearing a coat several sizes too large and carrying a library card she kept checking as if afraid it would disappear. She had clearly been looking for something else — a particular reference section, from the look of the title she had written on the back of her hand in blue ink — and had found this instead.

She stood in the doorway for a long moment.

"Can I come in?" she asked.

"Yes," said Natalia.

The girl came in and stood at the center of the room, where the lantern's warmth was strongest, and turned slowly in the way Natalia had turned on the first day — watching the names wake on the shelves, reading the ones she could make out, her expression moving through surprise and then stillness and then something more careful than either.

"Are those real names?" she asked.

"Yes," Maya said. "Real people who came here and read. The lantern remembers them."

"Why?"

Natalia thought about how to answer in a way that was true without being more than a person needed in their first minute in a new room. "So that the next person who comes knows they're not the first."

The girl was quiet for a moment. "I'm looking for a book about being the new person in a school," she said. "My class already has everyone's friends already decided."

Maya opened her mouth to say something immediate and kind. Alana reached for her tablet. But it was SPARK who moved first — quietly, without announcement — to the shelves, where the lantern was already waking a cluster of names near the third section: seven readers, across different decades, who had each come in months that the ledger noted as transition months. September. January. The middle of an ordinary week.

"There is a section here," SPARK said gently, "for books about finding your place in places that already have their places arranged." He projected a small arrow. "The lantern has been pointing to it since you walked in."

The girl followed the arrow. She stood before the relevant shelf and read the spines. Her finger stopped at one.

She took it down. She sat on the floor beside the return shelf, where the ledger sat in its new home, and she opened the book and read the first page.

After a moment she looked up at the ledger. "What's that?"

"A record of every reader who has come to this room," Natalia said. "And why they came."

"Will my name go in it?"

Natalia picked up the pen — the archivist's pen, which had somehow reinked itself, as old faithful tools sometimes do. She opened the ledger to the next page, which existed now: a blank page that had not been there before, grown from somewhere inside the binding.

"When you're ready to say why it mattered," Natalia said, "yes."

The girl nodded and returned to her book.

The lantern held every name in the room warmly and without distinction — the fifty-year-old names and the new ones and the one being formed right now, one page at a time, in the hands of a girl who had needed to find that she was not the first.

Chapter 12 — Light for the Next Reader

They did not leave the room empty-handed, and they did not leave it the way they had found it.

The shelves they had spent two days learning were slightly reorganized — not arbitrarily, but according to a system Alana had developed from the ledger's own internal patterns: the books that appeared most frequently in entries about loneliness placed near the door, where someone arriving uncertain would find them first. The books about difficult decisions deeper in, where you had to walk a little way before reaching them, because those books required some settling before they could help. The scientific histories and the natural records given their own quiet corner with better lamp-light, because the readers who came for those books, the ledger suggested, tended to stay longest and needed to see clearly.

Maya found the missing volume that had left a gap in Alana's section: it had been shelved incorrectly, two rows over, behind a taller spine that had hidden it. She replaced it and watched a name she now recognized — a reader

who had come three years in a row — reappear in the wood beside it, complete again.

"Odessa P. is back," she said, quietly.

SPARK began a supplemental catalogue of the room's holdings, cross-referenced with the ledger, so that future visitors would be able to search by need as well as by title. He was careful to preserve the handwritten entries exactly as they were — no corrections for spelling, no standardization of dates that had been recorded in different formats across decades. The irregularities were part of the record. They were evidence that many different hands had touched this work.

On the return shelf beside the ledger, Natalia added a small card in the archivist's style:

This ledger is a record of readers. If you have come here and found what you needed, or if you have come and are still looking, you are welcome to add your name. The lantern will remember.

She signed it not with a name but with the initials they had used to sign everything collaborative since they were small: N., A., M. & S.

Then she stood at the door and looked back at the room one last time before they left.

The lantern burned clean and gold. On every shelf, names flickered gently in its light — Thomas and Priya and Daniel and Odessa and the girl in the too-large coat and all the rest, two thousand names and counting, the enormous quiet company of everyone who had needed a book and had found one, everyone who had needed to know they were not alone in the experience of being alive and uncertain and trying.

Alana retrieved her compass from the door's recess mechanism. The door did not close.

"It's staying open now," she said.

"Good," said Maya.

They walked out into the eastern corridor of the labyrinth. The tide atlases stood in their familiar places. The miniature globes caught the overhead light. Ordinary shelves, ordinary afternoon, except for the warmth at their backs from the open door and the sound — barely audible, easily missed — of a flame that had been burning for twelve years and had no intention of stopping.

SPARK fell into step beside them. "New catalogue entry filed. Room designation updated to: open, monitored, recommended."

"Recommended," Natalia said. She was still thinking about the girl on the floor with the book in her lap and the ledger within reach, reading her way into a room where other people's names were waiting to be good company.

"For readers who need to know," SPARK confirmed.

Which was, in the end, what every room in the labyrinth was for.

THE END